

Shaky U.S.-Iran talks risk collapse

Strikes by Pentagon and Israeli attacks in Lebanon undermine hopes for end to war.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND NABIH BULOS

WASHINGTON — Precarious talks to end the war with Iran appeared close to collapse on Tuesday as renewed fighting across the region threatened to derail fragile progress toward a comprehensive settlement.

U.S. strikes against targets in southern Iran — the first since a ceasefire was declared in the war seven weeks ago — coupled with escalating attacks by Israel in Lebanon have undermined optimism that an agreement was within reach.

The attacks occurred just hours after U.S. and Iranian diplomats arrived in Qatar for peace talks. Iran's top negotiators left Doha on Tuesday without comment. News of the strikes, and threats of retaliation by Tehran, sent global oil prices soaring back to more than \$100 a barrel.

U.S. Central Command described Monday's actions as "self-defense strikes" that were restrained and modest in scope, targeting missile launch sites and Iranian boats "attempting to emplace mines" in the Strait of Hormuz.

But the attack came as President Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio had been projecting confidence that a framework agreement to end the war could be reached within days. Under the proposed deal, Iran would restore the strait to its prewar status as a free and open international waterway, while both sides entered 60 days of negotiations over the removal of Iran's nuclear stockpile.

Laying mines in the strait in the eleventh hour of the negotiations could signal to the Trump administration that Iran is not serious about reopening traffic there. But the Iranians said

[See **Mideast**, A3]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

WATER, at top, is sprayed on an overheated tank at GKN Aerospace in Garden Grove. Above, evacuees Allan Chaidez and his dad return to their Stanton home.

Industry knew for years about ‘runaway’ risks

Chemical tank failures like one that forced 50,000 to flee in O.C. have killed, hurt many.

By HANNAH FRY AND RONG-GONG LIN II

The chemical industry has been well aware of the risks of the type of thermal runaway reaction that forced 50,000 people from their homes in Orange County last weekend, reviving years of warnings from researchers about the potential dangers.

Nearly 15% of incidents in the U.S. involving uncontrolled chemical reactions from 1980 to 2001 were thermal runaway incidents that involved rapid polymerization of a chemical, according to a study published in the journal ACS Omega, citing information from the U.S. Chemical Safety and Hazard Investigation Board.

Such incidents have led to deaths globally, but some experts say the industry has struggled to improve safety.

In Orange County, the crisis was sparked by thousands of gallons of a highly toxic chemical in a failing, pressurized tank that was heating up at a Garden Grove aerospace firm. There was a potential of fire or flash fire over many city blocks, and there were busi-

nesses, dozens of homes and an elementary school in a potential damage blast zone.

The worst-case scenario was averted over the Memorial Day weekend. But serious questions remain over how such a near-disaster could have happened.

Authorities suspect that the cooling system responsible for maintaining the temperature of a tank filled with a hazardous chemical at GKN Aerospace failed, leading to the crisis at the facility that triggered evacuations, Orange County Fire Authority interim Chief T.J. McGovern said Tuesday.

This probably led to a buildup of heat in the pressurized tank filled with 7,000 gallons of a highly reactive liquid chemical called methyl methacrylate, or MMA, which can be used to make items such as Plexiglass as well as household goods.

"We don't know why, but it stopped cooling," McGovern said. "So that's what started this event, to where the product heated up and it off-gassed through the relief valve, and that's how this whole response started. We're just now being able to get to the tanks, so there's definitely more to come of what caused it."

Fire officials and experts were faced with a seemingly no-win situation: a "boiling" [See **Warnings**, A6]

Bass in fight of her political life

On her first day in office in 2022, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass promised voters bold action, standing with her allies as she declared a local emergency on homelessness.

That moment of political stagecraft, meant to herald a new era of confident leadership, seems like a political lifetime ago.

Bass, running in the June 2 primary for a second and final term, faces the toughest reelection fight of her political career. Many voters now associate her with an entirely different emergency — the devastating 2025 Palisades fire — and view the response under her leadership as a failure.

Seeking reelection, mayor must defend record on police raises, homelessness, Palisades fire

By DAVID ZAHNISER

"I think the city turned on her after the fires," said Michael Trujillo, a Democratic political strategist not involved in the mayor's race. "We saw an office and an administration that was not well equipped for a crisis."

City Councilmember Nithya Raman, who applauded the mayor at her emergency declaration event, is now looking to unseat her. Reality TV personality Spencer Pratt, whose home was destroyed in the Palisades fire, is waging his own insurgent campaign, portraying homeless residents as a danger to stroller-pushing moms.

Bass' campaign has acknowledged that it doesn't [See **Bass**, A7]

When hillside home dream runs into zoning code reality

Years and \$73,000 in fees later, one project in Mount Washington hasn't broken ground.

By JACK FLEMMING

Andri Luescher isn't complaining. He's just tired.

In 2022, the architect bought a small vacant lot in the hills of Mount Washington with plans to build a modest home for his family of four. He still hasn't broken ground.

For the last few years, he's been mired in a complex web of mounting fees and permit nightmares, getting punted back and forth among city departments like a fraying football. Before a single shovel hit the dirt, he spent \$5,000 on reports documenting native trees on the property — all three of them. He paid \$17,000 applying for exemptions so he doesn't have to widen his future neighbors' streets for them. And he sat through hours in public meetings where those same neighbors weigh in on what they like and don't like about his project.

A 1,400-square-foot house, mind you. Three bedrooms. Two bathrooms.

The bane of the project is the Mount Washington/Glassell Park Specific Plan. Adopted in 1993, the ordinance dictates development

in the neighborhood in order to maintain its identity as a quiet, verdant retreat in the hills northeast of downtown L.A.

Specific plans are a crucial component of responsible development in L.A. The city has 52 of them in areas such as the Crenshaw Corridor, Mulholland Scenic Parkway and Pacific Palisades, and they serve as a vital tool in an era of mansionization, where profit-hungry developers build bigger and bigger houses — sometimes so big that they're in danger of sliding down hills and crushing the homes beneath them.

But in Luescher's neighborhood, the plan was adopted to solve a problem that, in many ways, has since been solved. Years ago, the city adopted two streamlined ordinances that regulate hillside buildings: scaling back home sizes, protecting trees, setting design standards, etc.

But since the Mount Washington plan was adopted before those, it supersedes them.

"If I was building this house in the hills of Silver Lake or Echo Park, approval would take six months," Luescher said. "But under this plan, it takes anywhere from two to five years."

The plan itself isn't even that restrictive, Luescher said. Smaller square [See **House**, A11]

The L.A. Phil's post-Dudamel era now has its music director



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI L.A. Times
BRITISH conductor Daniel Harding will step into his new role in 2027.

MARK SWED
CLASSICAL
MUSIC CRITIC

The Los Angeles Philharmonic announced Tuesday that it has named Daniel Harding the orchestra's 12th music director, ending three years of intense speculation over the orchestra's future after Gustavo Dudamel leaves in August to head the New York Philharmonic.

Harding will begin a six-year contract for up to a dozen weeks of concerts a season, beginning in the fall of 2027, roughly 30 years after the British prodigy made his U.S. debut conducting the

L.A. Phil at the 1997 Ojai Festival. It was a nervous-making trial by fire that began as a nail-biter. But by the festival's end, the wunderkind had excitedly found his way with the orchestra.

Harding has since become a favorite, if occasional, L.A. Phil guest conductor while rising to the top rungs of the international orchestral circuit, along with obtaining a commercial flying license and piloting, now and then, for Air France. He led a pair of superior Rachmaninoff programs in his belated debut at the Hollywood Bowl last summer shortly after one of Du-

[See **Harding**, A6]

‘Rough sleepers’ more common

A group's count in Hollywood finds more homeless people on the streets without tents or in cars. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Los Angeles stars as itself on TV

As the city tries to lure back production, some series are showing off its neighborhood. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Misty morning.
L.A. Basin: 69/55. **B6**



TIMOTHY A. CLARY AFP/Getty Images

U.S. WORLD CUP TEAM SET

Coach Mauricio Pochettino details his decisions as the 26-man roster for next month's tournament is revealed in a televised event. **SPORTS, B10**

GOP's vote map plans hit a snag

South Carolina Senate declines to redraw districts and Alabama is blocked.

By KIM CHANDLER AND DAVID A. LIEB

COLUMBIA, S.C. — President Trump's push to reshape congressional districts ahead of the November elections suffered a double setback Tuesday, as South Carolina senators declined to do so and a federal court blocked a Republican-backed map in Alabama.

As early in-person voting began Tuesday in South Carolina's primaries, the state Senate rejected a Republican plan to cancel those congressional votes and instead schedule a new primary under revised districts designed to help the GOP oust a longtime Democrat.

Some senators said it was simply too late to make a change.

"South Carolina citizens are going to the polls today. And neither my conscience or common sense is going to let me stop an election that is already underway," Republican state Sen. Richard Cash said.

The political drama in South Carolina is part of a Republican strategy — propelled by Trump — to redraw voting districts to the GOP's advantage in an attempt to hold on to a slim House majority in the midterm elections. Republicans have been moving quickly to try to leverage a recent U.S. Supreme Court ruling that weakened minority protections under the federal Voting Rights Act.

In Alabama, a three-judge federal panel issued a preliminary injunction blocking the state from using a Republican-drawn congressional map that could help the GOP win an additional seat. The court said the plan "intentionally discriminated based on race" by including only one [See **Maps**, A5]